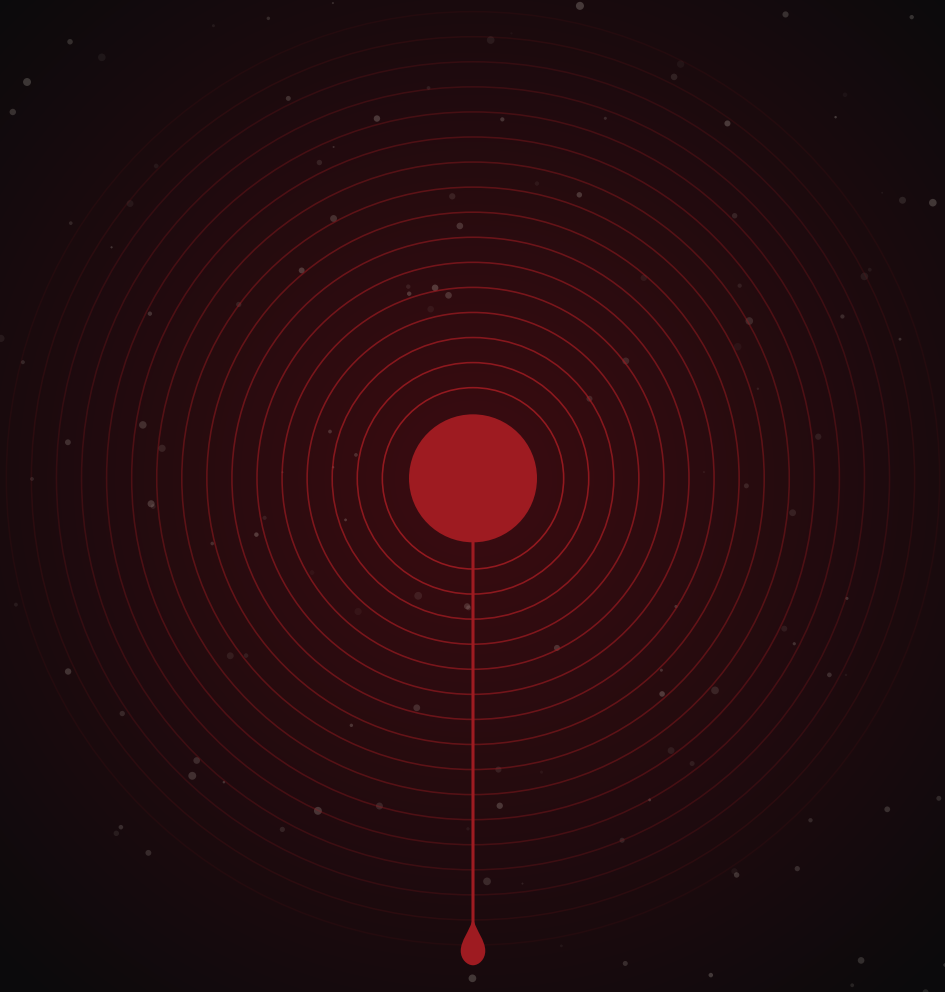


THE WILLFUL ARM

Telekinesis, Abjection, and the Sovereign Girl in the Carrie *Corpus, 1974–2026*

TOWARD A HAPTIC HUMANISM

A DISSERTATION · OCTOBER 2026

“Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live.”

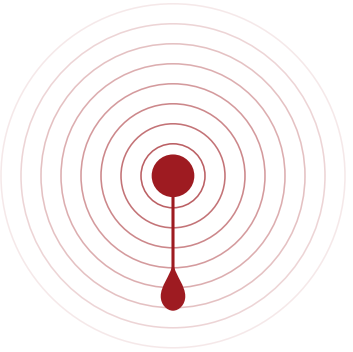
EXODUS 22:18

“Touch me not.”

JOHN 20:17

“I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend.”

MARY SHELLEY, FRANKENSTEIN (1818)



A DISSERTATION

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6 OCTOBER 2026

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Abstract

THIS DISSERTATION READS the *Carrie* corpus—Stephen King's novel (1974); Brian De Palma's film from Lawrence D. Cohen's screenplay (1976); Katt Shea's *The Rage: Carrie 2* (1999) and David Carson's telefilm from Bryan Fuller's teleplay (2002); Kimberly Peirce's film from the screenplay by Cohen and Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa (2013); and Mike Flanagan's eight-part series (2026)—as a single distributed text: a myth that has re-expressed itself roughly once a generation for fifty-two years. It advances three claims.

First, the corpus's master trope, telekinesis, figures not "female power" in the abstract but a specific and historically impossible synthesis: the capacity to act upon the world at a distance joined to the guarantee that one's own body cannot be touched. These are the two founding endowments of the liberal-humanist subject from Pico della Mirandola through Locke and Kant, and they were conferred on the tacit condition that the leaking, bleeding, touchable female body be excluded from them. Granted to a menstruating girl, the humanist endowment can register only as apocalypse. I name the figure who results the **Sovereign Abject**: a subject who occupies, first in sequence and then simultaneously, both poles of Giorgio Agamben's sovereign relation—*homo sacer*, whom anyone may degrade with impunity, and the sovereign who decides the exception.

Second, the adaptations do not merely repeat the story; they retry it. From René Girard's reading of Satan as the accuser and the Paraclete as the advocate for the defense, I derive a theory of **paracletic adaptation**: each version reopens the case of Carietta White before a new historical tribunal, and the verdict migrates from monstrosity (1974/1976) through systemic indictment (1999), clemency (2002), and vindication (2013), toward Flanagan's genealogical rehearing, which relocates Carrie within a transhistorical sorority of gifted and persecuted women (2026). The novel prophesied this structure. Its documentary form already constitutes a tribunal, and its closing letter—announcing the same faculty in another infant girl—already theorizes the myth's own **recessive inheritance**.

Third, the corpus repeatedly reaches for an image it cannot sustain: the hand of one girl closing on the hand or body of another. From the telepathic communion that ends the novel, through De Palma's arm rising from the grave—read here, with Sara Ahmed, through the Grimms' tale of the willful child whose arm will not stay buried—to Fuller's resuscitating breath and Peirce's palm laid on a pregnant belly,

the corpus sketches an ethics that the sovereign model forecloses. The dissertation concludes by formalizing that ethics as a **haptic humanism**: an account of the human grounded not in inviolability and action-at-a-distance but in the reversibility of touching and being touched (Merleau-Ponty, Irigaray, Nancy), in the shared exposure Judith Butler calls precarity, and in the erotic as Audre Lorde understood it—a power felt with others rather than exercised upon them. Its closing formula is a change of prefix: from *tele-* (the far, the sovereign) to *para-* (the beside, the advocate).

Note on the Corpus, Sigla, and Dating

THE CORPUS COMPRISES six screen and print texts and one theatrical paratext. The third node assigned to this study contains two distinct productions that are often conflated: *The Rage: Carrie 2* (1999), directed by Katt Shea from Rafael Moreu's screenplay as a sequel to the 1976 film, and the NBC telefilm *Carrie* (2002), directed by David Carson from Bryan Fuller's teleplay as a re-adaptation of the novel. They are treated together in Chapter 4 because they bracket the Columbine massacre and jointly constitute the corpus's millennial interregnum. *Carrie: The Musical* (book by Lawrence D. Cohen, music by Michael Gore, lyrics by Dean Pitchford; Broadway, 1988; revised revival, 2012) is cited as a paratext, chiefly because it makes Cohen the corpus's custodial author across 1976, 1988, and 2013.

SIGLUM	TEXT AND AUTHORSHIP	FRAME	FATE OF THE TELEKINETIC GIRL	VERDICT (CH. 8)
C74	Stephen King, *Carrie* (Doubleday, 1974)	Documentary collage: commission testimony, scholarship, memoir, wire bulletins	Dies, outside the roadhouse, of the knife wound her mother inflicted, in telepathic communion with Sue Snell	An open case the archive cannot close
C76	Brian De Palma, from Lawrence D. Cohen's screenplay (United Artists, 1976)	Linear narrative; the camera replaces the archive	Dies as the house collapses; returns as an arm in Sue's dream	Monstrosity mitigated by pathos
R99	Katt Shea, from Rafael Moreu's screenplay (United Artists/MGM, 1999)	Sequel; inheritance through a half-sister, Rachel Lang	Rachel burns after saving Jesse Ryan	Systemic indictment
C02	David Carson, from Bryan Fuller's teleplay (NBC, 2002)	Police interviews framing flashback	Revived by Sue, her death faked, smuggled to Florida	Clemency
C13	Kimberly Peirce, from the screenplay by Cohen and Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa (MGM/Screen Gems, 2013)	Linear, with a birth prologue and Sue's court testimony	Dies under a rain of stones after saving Sue	Vindication
C26	Mike Flanagan and writers' room (Prime Video, 2026)	911 calls and a true-crime documentary; episodes devoted to other gifted women	Open at the time of writing	Genealogical rehearing

This dissertation is dated 6 October 2026, the eve of C26's release on 7 October 2026. Chapter 6 therefore works from the series' published architecture, its showrunner's statements, and the first wave of critical response from screenings of all eight episodes; its conclusions are framed as hypotheses to be tested against the full text. A television tie-in edition of the novel carrying an introduction by Margaret Atwood appeared from Vintage on 29 September 2026, linking the corpus paratextually to the canonical feminist fiction of reproductive theocracy (Wikipedia: *Carrie* (miniseries)).

1486/1974

The Humanist, the Witch, and the Girl in the Shower

I. *Two documents of 1486*

IN 1486 TWO texts were composed within a few months of each other that, read together, constitute the genetic code of the problem this dissertation addresses. In Rome, the twenty-three-year-old Giovanni Pico della Mirandola drafted the oration meant to open his public disputation of nine hundred theses, later titled the *Oration on the Dignity of Man*. Its founding fable has God address Adam as a creature without fixed seat, form, or office, free by the judgment of his own will to degenerate into the brutes or to be reborn among the divine: the human as chameleon, the being whose essence is self-fashioning. In Speyer, the Dominican inquisitor Heinrich Kramer (Institoris), with the nominal co-authorship of Jacob Sprenger, published the *Malleus Maleficarum*, which systematized the claim that witchcraft proceeds from carnal appetite, that this appetite is insatiable in women, and that the female body—humid, porous, subject to flux—is the natural gateway of the demonic. The *Malleus* also systematized a procedure: denunciation, interrogation, the compilation of testimony into a dossier, the search of the accused body for marks.

The two texts are customarily shelved in different histories, one of emancipation and one of persecution. This dissertation proposes that they are a single history read from opposite sides. The dignity Pico ascribed to *homo*—mobility, selftransformation, the power to act upon one's own nature and upon the world—was articulated in the very decade in which its negative was codified: the woman whose capacity to act upon the world without visible means (*maleficium*, harm worked at a distance by look, word, or will) was the definition of her crime. What humanism called dignity when exercised by the self-fashioning man, demonology called witchcraft when exercised by the bleeding woman. Telekinesis—the power to move matter without touching it—is the exact point at which the two definitions coincide. Carrie White stands at their intersection. She possesses Pico's power, bears the *Malleus*'s accusation, and is raised by a mother who treats Exodus 22:18 ("Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live") as household law.

II. *1974: the archive of a girl*

King's novel appeared on 5 April 1974 inside a theoretical conjuncture it did not know it belonged to. That academic year Michel Foucault delivered the Collège de France lectures later published as *Abnormal* (1974–75), which trace the descent of the "human monster," the "individual to be corrected," and the masturbating child as the founding figures of modern normalization; the year before, his seminar had published *I, Pierre Rivière…*, a dossier of medical, juridical, and journalistic discourses assembled around a young parricide and his own memoir. Luce Irigaray's *Speculum of the Other Woman* appeared in 1974; Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" and Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" in 1975; Adrienne Rich's *Of Woman Born*, Foucault's *History of Sexuality*, Richard Dawkins's *The Selfish Gene*, and De Palma's film in 1976. The novel arrived a year after *Roe v. Wade* and two years after Title IX, whose implementing regulations were then reorganizing the American girls' gymnasium—the room in which *Carrie* opens—into a site of federal gender administration.

Carrie is not an illustration of this conjuncture but one of its primary documents. It was written by a twenty-six-year-old schoolteacher and former industrial launderer, outside every institution that produced the others, and it arrives independently at their shared problem: how a society reads, records, and disciplines the body of a girl, and what that body does when the reading becomes intolerable.

III. *Thesis*

The six texts are approached here not as an original and its copies but as a single distributed work whose meaning is legible only across its iterations. The governing thesis is that the corpus constitutes a fifty-two-year thought experiment about the human, in which telekinesis is the experimental variable: what follows when the humanist endowment of sovereign agency—action at a distance plus bodily inviolability—is conferred upon the figure whose exclusion constituted it?

The answer unfolds in three propositions. The first is diagnostic: the endowment produces neither liberation nor mere monstrosity but a structurally novel figure, the **Sovereign Abject**, who passes from the position of the one whom all may violate to the position of the one who decides who may live, and whose catastrophe exposes the monstrosity latent in sovereignty itself. The second is historiographical: the adaptations function as successive retrials of the novel's unclosed case, each convened before a new tribunal and each shifting the burden of guilt from the girl toward the community, a process I call **paracletic adaptation** and whose generational rhythm the novel itself theorized as a **recessive inheritance**. The third is normative: in its recurring and repeatedly suppressed image of one girl's hand reaching for another, the corpus discloses an alternative to sovereignty, here

formalized as a **haptic humanism**, in which the human is defined by the reversibility of touch rather than by the capacity to act without being touched.

IV. *Method*

Fidelity criticism is set aside at the outset. Following Robert Stam's dialogics of adaptation, Thomas Leitch's critique of the fallacies of source-primacy, and Linda Hutcheon's account of adaptation as repetition without replication, each version is read both as an interpretation of the novel's open case and as a document of its own historical structure of feeling, in Raymond Williams's sense. The analysis braids five discourses that are rarely held together: the anthropology and psychoanalysis of pollution (Mary Douglas, Julia Kristeva, Barbara Creed); political theology and the theory of sacrifice (Carl Schmitt, Giorgio Agamben, René Girard, Victor Turner); feminist and humanist political philosophy (Simone de Beauvoir, Hannah Arendt, Carole Pateman, Judith Butler, Wendy Brown, Miranda Fricker); the philosophy of anger (Audre Lorde, Amia Srinivasan, Martha Nussbaum, Susan Stryker); and the phenomenology of touch (Maurice Merleau-Ponty, Irigaray, Jean-Luc Nancy, Jacques Derrida, Emmanuel Levinas, Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick).

Scripture is quoted from the King James Version, which is at once public property and the textual idiom of Margaret White's Protestantism. The novel is cited by its internal documents rather than by pagination, both because editions vary and because the documents are themselves the novel's argument. Claims about authorial intention are confined to the authors' published statements; claims about meaning are made at the level of the texts.

V. *Plan of the work*

Part I (Chapters 1–2) reconstructs the matrix: King's documentary form as a disciplinary apparatus, and the theology and anthropology of menstrual abjection the novel stages. Part II (Chapter 3) reads De Palma and Cohen's substitution of a scopic regime for an archival one. Part III (Chapter 4) treats the millennial interregnum of Shea and Moreu's sequel and Carson and Fuller's telefilm, which bracket Columbine. Part IV (Chapter 5) reads Peirce, Cohen, and Aguirre-Sacasa's superheroic settlement. Part V (Chapter 6) offers a provisional reading of Flanagan's series. Part VI (Chapters 7–8) builds the theory of the Sovereign Abject and of paracletic adaptation. The Conclusion derives the haptic humanism from the corpus's final images.

PART ONE

I

The Matrix

Stephen King's novel, 1974

CHAPTER 1 · THE DOSSIER AND THE BODY
CHAPTER 2 · THE CURSE OF BLOOD

CHAPTER ONE

The Dossier and the Body

King's Documentary Form as Disciplinary Apparatus

1.1 *A custodian's authorship*

KING'S OWN ACCOUNT of the novel's genesis, given in *On Writing* (2000), is a primal scene of trespass mediated by labor. Working as a high-school janitor, he entered the girls' locker room and saw the dispensers for sanitary products—fixtures of a bodily regime he had never been permitted to see. He joined that image to a magazine article speculating that poltergeist phenomena might be telekinetic in origin and might cluster around adolescent girls at puberty. He drafted three pages, discarded them, and resumed only when Tabitha King retrieved them from the wastebasket and offered to supply the knowledge of girls' lives he lacked. He has written that Carrie was assembled partly from two girls of his own schooldays, whom he disguises under pseudonyms: one mocked for wearing the same clothes to school every day, the other raised by a fanatically religious mother. Both died before they were thirty, one by suicide and the other of an epileptic seizure, alone in her apartment (Kindling; Looper). He has also confessed that he never liked Carrie and never trusted Sue Snell's motives. In *Danse Macabre* (1981) he described the novel as concerned with how women find their own channels of power and with what men fear in women and in women's sexuality.

These statements are not keys to meaning, but they disclose a structural position. King writes as a custodian: the man who cleans up after the female body, who enters its spaces only to maintain them, and who knows it through its residues. The novel's documentary form is the formal analogue of that position. King writes Carrie as institutions write her—from outside, by evidence, after the fact. The decisive interpretive question is whether the form merely reproduces the custodial gaze or exposes it. This chapter argues that it does both, and that the tension is generative.

1.2 *The case as genre*

The novel interleaves third-person narration with excerpts from a scholarly monograph, *The Shadow Exploded*, by a male academic; the hearings of the White Commission; Sue Snell's memoir, *My Name Is Susan Snell*; scientific articles; and wire

bulletins issued as Chamberlain burns. Its lineage is the Victorian case-novel. Wilkie Collins opened *The Woman in White* (1859–60) by announcing that his story would be told as an offence is tried in court, by successive witnesses, each speaking to what he knew; its plot concerns a woman wrongfully confined in an asylum. The rhyme of surnames is a coincidence that becomes an argument: Collins's Woman in White and King's Carrie White are both women whose truth is litigated by others. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), the model for King's next novel, perfected the form as a technology of containment: typewriters, phonograph cylinders, and shorthand diaries assemble a modern archive that defeats an archaic monster.

King inverts the inheritance. In Collins and Stoker the dossier closes the case. In *Carrie* it cannot. The experts contradict one another, the science is speculative, the Commission inconclusive, and the memoir partial. Foucault's *I, Pierre Rivière*… (1973) offers the closer analogue: a dossier in which medical, juridical, and journalistic discourses converge on a young killer, and in which the killer's own memoir exceeds every discourse that tries to explain it. The novel's archive is likewise organized around an excess—Carrie's interiority, rendered in italicized fragments of thought, and Sue's telepathic testimony—that no institutional genre can admit as evidence. Mikhail Bakhtin would call the result heteroglossia, but the description is too irenic. The novel's voices do not converse; they compete for jurisdiction. Its polyphony is litigation.

The temporal structure deepens the effect. Published in 1974, the novel sets its events in a near-future 1979 and quotes documents dated later still. It is an archive of the future, written in the future perfect: Carrie is always already what will have happened, always already a case. This prolepsis is the formal correlate of Margaret White's Calvinism. The novel is predestinarian in its architecture; the reader knows Carrie's end before her beginning, as the elect were said to know the reprobate.

1.3 *Testimony and its injustices*

Miranda Fricker's distinction between testimonial injustice, a credibility deficit caused by identity prejudice, and hermeneutical injustice, a gap in shared interpretive resources, maps the novel's epistemic field with precision. Sue's testimony before the Commission is shadowed by suspicion that she conspired in the prank, and her account of a telepathic communion with the dying Carrie is inadmissible under any evidentiary rule. Her memoir is therefore a defense brief, written because the tribunal would not hear her. The structure inverts Salem. In 1692 the spectral evidence of afflicted girls was credited and killed nineteen people by hanging; in *Carrie*, a girl's spectral evidence is discredited precisely when it would exonerate. Between these poles lies the whole history of the female witness to the extraordinary, believed when she accuses and doubted when she defends.

The hermeneutical injustice belongs to Carrie herself and is the subject of Chapter 2: she meets her menarche without the concept of menstruation, and so experiences a normal process as a mortal wound. The novel thus opens with a hermeneutical injustice and closes with a testimonial one. Between them lies the massacre, which might be read as what happens when a person denied both the concepts to understand herself and the credibility to explain herself acquires a third resource: force.

1.4 *Heredity, biopolitics, and the other Carrie*

The scientific voices in the dossier treat the telekinetic faculty, abbreviated *TK*, as heritable, and turn at once to the questions of detection and management. This is the voice of what Foucault called biopower: the administration of populations through the statistics of birth, heredity, and risk. The voice had a recent and specific history. In *Buck v. Bell* (1927) the Supreme Court upheld the compulsory sterilization of Carrie Buck, a poor young Virginian whose mother had been institutionalized and whose infant daughter was assessed as defective, under Justice Holmes's judgment that three generations of imbeciles were enough. Paul Lombardo's archival work has since shown that Buck's pregnancy followed her rape by Clarence Garland, nephew of her foster mother, Alice Dobbs, and that the Dobbses' petition to commit her concealed the crime; the State of Virginia then sterilized her at its Colony for Epileptics and Feebleminded under its superintendent, John Bell, whose name the case bears. The homonym is not a source, and no claim of influence is made. It is a structural rhyme that discloses the genealogy of the novel's scientific register: a hereditarian science that read a girl's sexual victimization as her own degeneracy, traced the defect through the maternal line, and proposed to stop it at the level of reproduction.

The novel's parapsychology belongs to a second genealogy. The early 1970s saw laboratory tests of the spoon-bending performer Uri Geller at the Stanford Research Institute and, in October 1974, Russell Targ and Harold Puthoff's paper on information transmission under sensory shielding in *Nature*. Behind this vogue stood older lines of inquiry: Charles Fort's catalogues of anomalous falls of stones (*The Book of the Damned*, 1919); the psychoanalytic theory of the poltergeist associated with Nandor Fodor, which read the phenomenon as the dissociated conflict of an adolescent, often female, psyche; and, decisively, Shirley Jackson's *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959), whose Eleanor Vance had as a child been the center of a shower of stones upon her family's house. Carrie's childhood rain of stones is Eleanor's, transposed. Jackson is the corpus's matrilineal ancestor in three registers: the stones of *Hill House*, the communal stoning of "The Lottery" (1948), and the village mob that besieges the Blackwood sisters in *We Have Always Lived in the Castle*

(1962). In 2018 Mike Flanagan adapted *Hill House*; in 2026 he adapted *Carrie*. The stones close a circuit sixty-seven years long.

1.5 *The epilogue as theory*

The novel ends twice. Narratively, it ends inside Sue Snell: she follows the dying Carrie's mind across Chamberlain, shares her death from within, and then begins to bleed, a bleeding critics have read either as menstruation or as the loss of the pregnancy she had feared. The book that opened with one girl's first blood closes with another's, and the only intimacy it grants Carrie is a touch of minds in the act of dying. Documentarily, it ends with a private letter from Tennessee reporting that a toddler named Annie can move marbles without touching them.

The letter converts a case into a series and a singular monster into a recurrence. It is the novel's theory of its own afterlife: the faculty, and with it the story, is carried silently and expressed again when conditions permit. Every subsequent text in the corpus is, in this precise sense, Annie grown up. Chapter 8 develops the claim as a theory of recessive transmission. Here it suffices to note that the dossier, which could not close the case of Carietta White, ends by opening the next one.

CHAPTER TWO

The Curse of Blood

Menarche, Abjection, and the Theology of Untouchability

2.1 *The scene of menarche as hermeneutical injustice*

THE NOVEL OPENS in the showers after a girls' gym class. Carrie, years past the usual age, bleeds for the first time. Her mother has never told her what menstruation is, and she believes she is dying. Her classmates pelt her with tampons and sanitary napkins and take up the chant—"Plug it up"—that became the corpus's most durable phrase. Simone de Beauvoir's account of the girl in *The Second Sex* (1949) anticipates the scene almost clause by clause: menarche as the moment the girl discovers her body as alien flesh, the mother's silence, the horror that is not given by biology but manufactured by a social regime of secrecy and shame. Carrie's experience is Beauvoir's analysis carried to its limit case.

In Fricker's terms the scene is hermeneutical injustice weaponized. Carrie lacks the concept that would render her experience intelligible; her peers possess it and deploy the gap as an instrument of degradation. The cruelty is epistemic before it is physical. The girls laugh at what Carrie does not know about herself, and their laughter is the social form of a knowledge monopoly.

2.2 *Pollution, abjection, and the patriarchal bargain*

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defines dirt as matter out of place and reads pollution beliefs as the defense of social boundaries, with the orifices and emissions of the body—blood, milk, spittle—serving as models of a society's anxious margins. The locker-room scene is a purification rite: the group expels its polluted member to reaffirm its own cleanliness. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) radicalizes the account. The abject is what disturbs identity, system, and order; it is neither subject nor object but the jettisoned thing that makes the subject possible. Kristeva distinguishes two pollutants: excrement, which threatens identity from outside, and menstrual blood, which threatens it from within, endangering the relation between the sexes and the identity of each sex in the face of sexual difference.

What the novel adds to both theorists is the agency of girls in the abjection of a girl. Chris Hargensen does not merely mock Carrie; she polices the female body on behalf of a regime that will ultimately police her too. Deniz Kandiyoti's concept of the patriarchal bargain names the logic: women's enforcement of gender norms in exchange for relative advantage within them. The shower is a scene of intra-female abjection in which femininity secures itself by expelling its own unruly substance. Barbara Creed's chapter on *Carrie* in *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993), titled "Woman as Witch," and Shelley Stamp Lindsey's reading of the film's "monstrous puberty" establish the canonical feminist reading: the text locates horror in female adolescence itself. The present study accepts the diagnosis but rejects its finality. The corpus as a whole, as later chapters show, conducts a long argument against the equation it begins by staging.

2.3 *The theology of the curse*

Margaret White's theology literalizes a twentieth-century euphemism. Anglophone slang called menstruation "the curse"; Margaret derives it from Genesis 3:16 ("in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children") and reads her daughter's bleeding as proof of sin, the sign that Carrie has become a woman in the sense of becoming fallen. Behind her stand Tertullian's address to women as "the devil's gateway" in *De cultu feminarum*, the *Malleus*'s sexual demonology, and the New England Calvinism of Cotton Mather and of Jonathan Edwards's *Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God* (1741), in which the sinner dangles over the pit like a spider over a fire.

Two scriptural sites are decisive for the argument of this dissertation. The first is Leviticus 15:19, which prescribes that the menstruating woman "shall be put apart seven days: and whosoever toucheth her shall be unclean until the even." The menstruant is the untouchable *par excellence*, and the prohibition falls specifically on touch. Read against this law, telekinesis appears as a theological solution: the power to act upon the world without the polluting contact. Carrie can move everything while touching nothing. Her power is the Levitical regime's dream of perfect separation realized as nightmare—absolute agency, zero contact.

The second is the counter-scripture Margaret never reads: Mark 5:25–34, in which a woman who has bled for twelve years touches Jesus's garment and is healed. Jesus feels that "virtue had gone out of him"—the Greek is *dynamis*, power—and asks who touched him. She confesses, trembling; he calls her "daughter" and declares her whole. Here the bleeding woman's touch transmits not pollution but power, and power flows through contact rather than across distance. Leviticus 15 and Mark 5 are the two poles between which the corpus moves for fifty years.

Augustine supplies the third term. In *The City of God* (Book XIV) he argues that the mark of the Fall is the body's involuntary motion: since the soul disobeyed God,

the flesh disobeys the soul, and its members move without the will's command. Carrie's telekinesis in its first manifestations is exactly such motion—objects that move without her will, at the prompting of shame and fear. Margaret's horror at it is Augustinian. Telekinesis is concupiscence externalized: the involuntary motion of the fallen body extended to the world of things.

The closet in which Margaret imprisons Carrie has its own scriptural warrant. Matthew 6:6 instructs the believer to "enter into thy closet" and pray in secret; Margaret converts the Protestant prayer closet into a cell. The word's later meaning, anatomized by Sedgwick in *Epistemology of the Closet* (1990) as the regime of the open secret, is equally apt. Carrie's maturing body is the open secret Margaret tried to keep closeted, and the shower is where the secret is outed.

2.4 *"Plug it up": Lady Macbeth, the wandering womb, and the hydraulics of rage*

The chant demands that an aperture be closed. Its most illustrious precedent is Lady Macbeth's invocation to "make thick my blood, / Stop up th' access and passage to remorse," which Jenijoy La Belle read as a petition for amenorrhea: the stopping of female flow as the precondition of murderous agency. Two older medical fantasies complete the genealogy. Plato's *Timaeus* (91b–d) describes the womb as a creature desirous of children that, frustrated, wanders through the body causing distress—the doctrine that gave hysteria its name. Breuer and Freud's *Studies on Hysteria* (1895) reformulated the hydraulics: blocked affect converts into somatic symptom.

Carrie's telekinesis completes this lineage by exteriorizing it. It is the wandering womb become literal and outward-facing, a uterine force that leaves the body and moves the world. The corpus's internal physiology confirms the reading: the faculty quickens with menarche, intensifies with humiliation, and discharges in blood and water—the fire hoses of the 1976 gym, the sprinklers, the pig's blood itself. What the community tried to stopper returns as flood.

2.5 *Margaret White and the institution of motherhood*

Adrienne Rich's *Of Woman Born* (1976) distinguishes motherhood as experience from motherhood as institution—the patriarchal apparatus that colonizes the experience. Margaret is the institution internalized to the point of self-annihilation. Her account of Carrie's conception is an account of rape: her husband, Ralph White, forced himself on her, and the pleasure her body registered during the assault became, in her theology, the proof of her own damnation. That confession, together with her solitary childbirth after mistaking her pregnancy for a cancer, shows a woman as estranged from the knowledge of her own body as her daughter. The

hermeneutical injustice is intergenerational. Rich's term *matrophobia*, which she credits to Lynn Sukenick—the daughter's fear of becoming her mother—names Carrie's central struggle, and the closet is Kristeva's archaic maternal space rendered as architecture: womb and tomb at once.

Margaret belongs historically to the evangelical resurgence that produced Hal Lindsey's *The Late Great Planet Earth* (1970) and the rapture film *A Thief in the Night* (1972), but King makes her a sect of one. Her church is herself, and her theology is what Nietzsche called *ressentiment*: the imaginary revenge of the powerless, projected onto a God who will burn the sinners of Chamberlain on her behalf. The novel's cruelest irony is that her prayer is answered. Carrie executes the judgment Margaret fantasized. The daughter becomes the mother's God, and Margaret, unable to recognize her apocalypse when it arrives, names it Satan. Mary Daly's axiom in *Beyond God the Father* (1973), that a male God sacralizes male rule, here acquires a pathological corollary: Margaret worships the Father who stands in for the husband who violated her.

2.6 *The second-wave counter-text and the erased fat girl*

The novel appeared as the women's health movement was teaching menstruation as knowledge rather than shame: *Our Bodies, Ourselves*, first issued as a newsprint booklet in 1970 and commercially in 1973; Germaine Greer's provocation in *The Female Eunuch* (1970) that emancipation might be measured by a woman's ease with her own menstrual blood; Gloria Steinem's satire "If Men Could Menstruate" (1978), which argued that the stigma tracks power rather than biology. *Carrie* dramatizes, as horror, the cost of the regime those texts attacked.

One feature of the novel the screen has never reproduced is its heroine's body. King's Carrie is heavy and acne-marked; every screen Carrie has been played by a slender actress whose concealed beauty is revealed at the prom, an omission critics have noted on the occasion of Flanagan's series (Dread Central). Chelsea Quinn Yarbro read the novel as a Cinderella inverted; the screen restores the Cinderella. The substitution is not cosmetic. Kathleen LeBesco's study of fat identity turns on the double sense of *revolting*—disgusting and insurgent—and that pun is the novel's own. The literary Carrie's body revolts in both senses. The cinematic makeover converts a story about the revolt of the unlovely body into a story about misperceived beauty, relocating the injustice from the community's standards to its failure to see. It is the first of the corpus's many accommodations, and it is made before a single frame of the prom is shot.

PART TWO

II

The Scopic Regime

Brian De Palma and Lawrence D. Cohen, 1976

CHAPTER 3 · TO-BE-LOOKED-AT, TO-LOOK-AND-KILL

CHAPTER THREE

To-Be-Looked-At, To-Look-and-Kill

De Palma, Cohen, and the Medusan Reversal (1976)

3.1 *From archive to eye*

LAWRENCE D. COHEN'S screenplay removes the dossier entirely: no commission, no memoir, no bulletins. The story becomes linear and is focalized through a camera that is now the sole archivist, and the apocalypse contracts from a town to a gymnasium and a house. The change is one of regime, not merely of scale. The novel asks what happened and who is to blame, which are juridical questions. The film asks what we see and what seeing does, which are scopic ones. Cohen thereby became the corpus's custodial author: he later wrote the book of the 1988 Broadway musical, a failure that closed after five performances and lent its name to Ken Mandelbaum's history of musical flops, *Not Since Carrie* (1991), and he shares screenplay credit on the 2013 film. Through him the film, rather than the novel, became the corpus's operative source.

3.2 *The shower and the gaze*

The film opens with a slow tracking movement through a steam-softened locker room, scored to Pino Donaggio's lush theme, that presents the girls nude, in slow motion and soft focus, in the idiom of erotica. Laura Mulvey had published her account of woman's "to-be-looked-at-ness" the previous year, and the sequence became its most notorious horror instance. Its address is double. It solicits the voyeurism it then punishes, for the blood that interrupts the reverie is the abject real breaking the screen of scopic pleasure. The feminist critique of the sequence (Creed, Lindsey, Clover) is well founded, and the performers' ages do not answer it—Sissy Spacek was twenty-six—because the characters are adolescents, the film presents them as such, and the camera knows it.

De Palma's grammar is Hitchcock's, inherited with its contradictions. The school is named Bates High. The shower is the primal site of *Psycho* (1960). Donaggio's stabbing strings, which sound whenever Carrie's power flares, echo Bernard

Herrmann. The prom's red suffusion recalls the trauma-red of *Marnie* (1964), and the accelerating 360-degree dance recalls the spirals of *Vertigo* (1958). Tania Modleski argued in *The Women Who Knew Too Much* (1988) that Hitchcock's cinema is riven by an identification with women that it simultaneously punishes. De Palma exaggerates the ambivalence until it becomes structure: the film adores Carrie's face and assaults her body.

3.3 *The prom as sacrificial machine*

The coronation of Carrie and Tommy by a rigged ballot is a textbook instance of what Mikhail Bakhtin called carnival crowning and decrowning: the mock king elevated in order to be abused. Its deeper archetype is the mock coronation of the Passion (Matthew 27:29), the crown of thorns and reed scepter followed by blows. Victor Turner's rituals of status reversal, in which the lowly are briefly elevated in liminal time, ordinarily reinforce structure by letting it be inverted harmlessly. Here the inversion is a snare. René Girard supplies the mechanism: mimetic rivalries within a community are discharged through unanimous violence against a single victim, who is first sacralized and then expelled. The prom vote is manufactured unanimity, and the crown is the sacralization that precedes the expulsion.

The ritual fails because the victim refuses her role, and what Girard calls a sacrificial crisis follows: distinctions collapse and violence spreads without limit. De Palma's split-screen is the image of that collapse; the frame itself divides as the community's unanimity shatters. Laughter is the hinge. Margaret's prophecy that everyone will laugh at her daughter is fulfilled perceptually: in Carrie's point of view, distorted faces multiply in laughter, including that of the gym teacher Miss Collins, who in the film's objective register was not laughing. Prophecy and perception fuse. Henri Bergson's *Laughter* (1900) described laughter as a social corrective that punishes rigidity and eccentricity; the prom stages corrective laughter in its lethal form. Bakhtin's regenerative carnival laughter is nowhere available.

3.4 *The swine and the Lamb*

The pig's blood carries a dense theological charge. Swine are unclean under Leviticus 11:7. In Mark 5:1–13 the demons named Legion are cast into a herd of swine that rushes into the sea; the pig is the receptacle of the demonic multitude. In 1 Maccabees 1:47 and Daniel 11:31, the sacrifice of swine in the Temple under Antiochus IV is "the abomination that maketh desolate," the desecration that in apocalyptic literature (Mark 13:14) inaugurates the End. The prank performs an abomination of desolation on the community's own sanctuary; what follows is, in the logic of the genre, apocalypse.

Revelation completes the figure. The elect have "washed their robes, and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (7:14). Carrie White is washed in blood and made red, and the unclean animal's blood replaces the Lamb's; the purification rite is inverted to the letter of her surname. Revelation 6:16 names what follows: "the wrath of the Lamb," before which the kings of the earth call on the mountains to fall on them. The sacrificial lamb becomes the judge. Samson completes the typology (Judges 16): consecrated, blinded, and mocked at the Philistines' feast in the temple of Dagon, he pulls down the pillars and kills more in his death than in his life.

3.5 *Medusa without laughter*

Freud's "Medusa's Head" (1922) read the petrifying gaze as a figure of castration. Hélène Cixous answered in 1975 that Medusa is beautiful and laughing, and that women must laugh and write the body. Linda Williams argued in "When the Woman Looks" (1984) that in classical horror the woman's look at the monster recognizes an affinity between them. In *Carrie* woman and monster coincide, and the look kills: De Palma renders telekinesis as Carrie's widened stare. The film thus inverts Mulvey's economy, converting the object of the opening gaze into the subject of a lethal one. The inversion is incomplete in one decisive respect. Carrie never laughs. The laughter belongs to the crowd; the girl receives Medusa's eyes without Medusa's laugh. The film grants the petrifying look and withholds the liberating laughter, and that withholding is its tragic signature.

3.6 *Sebastian, Teresa, and the death of Margaret*

In novel and film alike Margaret strikes first, stabbing her daughter with a kitchen knife. In the novel Carrie answers by stopping her mother's heart. In the film Carrie drives knives and other kitchen implements into Margaret telekinetically, pinning her to a doorframe in the posture of the Saint Sebastian statue that presides over the closet. Sebastian, the plague saint pierced by arrows, was a Renaissance vehicle for the eroticized male nude and later a queer icon, from Oscar Wilde's alias Sebastian Melmoth to Yukio Mishima. Margaret's dying moans, poised between agony and rapture, recall Bernini's *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa* (1647–52), which Jacques Lacan in *Encore* (Seminar XX, 1972–73) offered as the emblem of a feminine jouissance beyond the phallic economy.

De Palma stages the death of the woman who forbade all pleasure as an orgasmic martyrdom. It is at once a misogynist joke and a psychoanalytic insight: the film punishes Margaret with the jouissance she prohibited and thereby names the repressed core of her theology. Carrie then dies holding her mother in the closet as the house falls, matrophobia resolved in a pietà. Both actresses, Sissy Spacek and

Piper Laurie, were nominated for Academy Awards, a rare recognition for performances in horror.

3.7 *Usher's arm: the coda and the paranoid structure*

The White house collapses and sinks, as Poe's House of Usher sinks into its tarn after Madeline returns bloodied from the tomb. Sue dreams that she lays flowers on the lot, where a For Sale sign has been defaced to proclaim that Carrie White burns in hell; an arm erupts from the earth and seizes her, and she wakes screaming in her mother's arms. Robin Wood's formula of the return of the repressed has rarely been literalized so exactly, and the sequence founded the modern horror coda later canonized by *Friday the 13th* (1980). In Sedgwick's terms it is paranoia as form: a structure that anticipates bad surprise and teaches that no ending is safe.

The arm is also something else, which the Conclusion develops: a hand that reaches. The film ends with two embraces—the dead arm's grip and the living mother's hold—neither of which can comfort. The corpus will spend fifty years trying to convert the first into a gesture that can.

3.8 *Bicentennial, born again*

The film opened on 3 November 1976, the day after Jimmy Carter, who had campaigned as a born-again Christian, won the presidency in the year *Newsweek* called the Year of the Evangelical. It joined *The Exorcist* (1973) and *The Omen* (1976) in a cycle that made the bodies of children and adolescents the battleground of the sacred. *Carrie* inverts *The Exorcist*: the demonic is projected onto the girl by her mother, and the true horror is the community's sacrificial machinery. De Palma's *The Fury* (1978), in which Amy Irving plays a telekinetic young woman pursued by a covert government program, extends the argument toward the state capture of the gifted—a line that runs through King's *Firestarter* (1980) and *The Institute* (2019) to Flanagan's sorority.

PART THREE

III

The Millennial Interregnum

Katt Shea and Rafael Moreu, 1999 · David Carson and Bryan Fuller, 2002

CHAPTER 4 · THE MILLENNIAL INTERREGNUM

CHAPTER FOUR

The Millennial Interregnum

Shea and Moreu (1999), Carson and Fuller (2002)

4.1 *Thirty-nine days*

The Rage: Carrie 2 opened on 12 March 1999. Thirty-nine days later, on 20 April, two seniors at Columbine High School in Colorado, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold, shot and killed twelve students and a teacher and wounded more than twenty others before killing themselves. The sequel is therefore the corpus's last pre-Columbine text, and the 2002 telefilm its first post-Columbine one. Columbine converted the revenge of the bullied from a genre fantasy into a publicsafety discourse; the early press framing of the two killers as persecuted outcasts, later contested in Dave Cullen's *Columbine* (2009), retroactively recast *Carrie* as a script. King had already let his Bachman novel *Rage* (1977), about a student who shoots his algebra teacher and holds his class hostage, go out of print. Copies had been linked to several school hostage-takings and shootings; the decisive case was the December 1997 shooting at a prayer meeting at Heath High School in West Paducah, Kentucky, where a fourteen-year-old student who kept the novel in his locker shot eight classmates, three of them fatally (Wikipedia: *Rage*). King examined the decision in the essay "Guns" (2013). That the sequel shares a title word with the withdrawn novel, and that its reported working titles included "The Curse" and "Say You're Sorry," condenses the interregnum's dilemma: the story's demand for an apology from the community now stood beside the community's demand for protection from the story.

4.2 The Rage*: from menstrual to sexual exposure*

Katt Shea, directing from Rafael Moreu's screenplay, relocates the humiliation from the leaking body to the exposed body. Rachel Lang (Emily Bergl), a goth outsider, loses her friend Lisa (Mena Suvari), who kills herself by jumping from the school roof after learning that Eric Stark, the eighteen-year-old football player she had slept with, did so as a move in a team competition to seduce as many girls as possible; Lisa was sixteen (Wikipedia: *The Rage: Carrie 2*). Commentators connect the premise to the 1993 "Spur Posse" scandal in Lakewood, California (retrospective essay), in

which a clique of Lakewood High School athletes kept a running score of sexual conquests; in March 1993 several members were arrested after complaints from girls, one of them a pre-teen, on charges including rape and unlawful intercourse with minors, and the district attorney dropped most of the charges (Wikipedia: Spur Posse). The decisive instrument of humiliation is no longer pig's blood but a videotape of Rachel and Jesse Ryan (Jason London) having sex for the first time, recorded covertly by his teammate Mark Bing and screened at a party with the claim that Jesse had been playing for points too (SF Encyclopedia; Slashfilm).

The film thereby converts the novel's question of the leaking body into a question of consent, and relocates cruelty from a chorus of girls to a fraternity of boys shielded by adults. Sue Snell (Amy Irving), now the school's guidance counselor, reports the pattern of discarded girls and is told by the coach that breaking a girl's heart is not illegal (Slashfilm). With the sheriff she pursues a statutory-rape charge against Eric, built on photographs of Lisa and Eric that Rachel gave the sheriff; the district attorney, pressed by the players' influential families, buries the charge, and the players turn on Rachel (Wikipedia). The party is therefore retaliation against a witness, and its instrument is itself a crime the film never names as one. Rachel, like Lisa, is a minor (Moria), so the covert recording and its screening are the production and distribution of sexual images of a child. *The Rage* is the first text in the corpus to name systemic misogyny—the athletic program, the legal establishment, the parental elite—as antagonist. It belongs to the moment of Susan Faludi's *Backlash* (1991), Mary Pipher's *Reviving Ophelia* (1994), and the riot grrrl and "girl power" vocabularies, and its authorship is itself an argument: a woman director recoding a male-authored cult text from inside a studio sequel.

4.3 *The father's gift and the institutionalized mother*

Rachel is Carrie's half-sister through Ralph White. The faculty now descends patrilineally, from a man whose serial paternity implies the sexual history the 1976 film had voiced only in Margaret's confession. The relocation is pointed: the daughters inherit power as the residue of the father's sexuality. Rachel's mother, institutionalized for psychosis, replaces the fundamentalist with the madwoman. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read Bertha Mason, who burns Thornfield, as the furious double of the Victorian heroine, and Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966) gave Bertha her own dream of fire. *The Rage* ends in fire as well.

As Rachel's power peaks, a tattoo spreads across her skin. The body becomes a text inscribed by rage, a secular stigmata. It is the corpus's first image of power as writing on the skin, and it anticipates the haptic argument of this dissertation: the organ of touch becomes the surface on which violence is legible.

4.4 *The tape as* pharmakon*; the advocate at the threshold*

The recording that humiliates also exonerates. The same tape captured Jesse whispering that he loved her while she slept; seeing it, Rachel reverses her verdict and uses her power to hurl him from a balcony to safety as the house burns around her. Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) read writing as *pharmakon*, poison and remedy at once. The recording medium, which will become the primary weapon in 2013 and 2026, enters the corpus already double: it is the community's archive of degradation and the only surviving evidence of love.

At the party Rachel turns her power on the players and their girlfriends who staged the screening and kills most of them (Wikipedia). Sue Snell, arriving too late, is killed at the threshold of the house, accidentally, in the course of Rachel's rampage. The advocate dies at the door of a tribunal she could not convene, killed by the fury she had tried to help Rachel contain. Irving's return makes Sue the corpus's only recurring performer-character across two texts and gives material form to the function Chapter 8 theorizes: the witness who persists from one hearing to the next.

4.5 *Fuller's restoration of the dossier*

The 2002 telefilm, directed by David Carson from Bryan Fuller's teleplay, aired on NBC on 4 November 2002 to some 12.2 million viewers (Wikipedia: *Carrie* (2002 film)). It restores the novel's juridical frame. A detective interviews survivors about the event the town has named the Black Prom, with Sue Snell (Kandyse McClure) as principal witness, and the narrative proceeds as testimony. Fuller also restores the childhood rain of stones, the destruction of the town, and Carrie's killing of her mother by stopping her heart; apart from its ending, critics regard it as the most faithful screen version (SF Encyclopedia; Film Stories).

The return of the interrogation room after Columbine is not neutral. The dossier comes back as the institutional response to a school catastrophe; investigation is the form in which post-Columbine culture metabolized school violence. The casting adds a dimension the text leaves implicit. A Black girl is questioned by a white detective about a white girl's violence, and her account must overcome both the suspicion of complicity and the racialized credibility deficit Patricia Hill Collins analyzed in the position of the "outsider within." Fricker's testimonial injustice here acquires a racial axis.

4.6 *Drowning and breath: the first resurrection*

Fuller's Margaret tries to drown her daughter—a lethal baptism—and Sue revives Carrie by cardiopulmonary resuscitation. It is the corpus's first resurrection and the first time the advocate's body touches the accused's. The theological resonance is

exact. In Genesis 2:7 God breathes into Adam the breath of life; in John 20:22 the risen Christ breathes on the disciples and says, "Receive ye the Holy Ghost." The Paraclete promised in John 14:16 is *pneuma*, breath. Fuller's Sue performs the paracletic function literally: she is the advocate who breathes. A telepathic exchange follows in which Carrie transfers her memories to Sue, so that the novel's inadmissible evidence becomes the ground of Sue's decision to hide her.

Fuller's subsequent work makes the haptic stakes retrospectively legible. *Dead Like Me* (2003) concerns a young woman who collects souls. *Pushing Daisies* (2007–09) concerns a man whose first touch revives the dead and whose second kills them forever, so that he may never touch the woman he loves—*noli me tangere* rendered as romantic comedy. *Hannibal* (2013–15) is a sustained study of intimacy between investigator and killer. Read backward, the 2002 *Carrie* inaugurates an oeuvre organized around the ethics of touch between the living and the dead.

4.7 *Clemency and its price*

The survival ending was dictated by the backdoor-pilot structure: Carrie and Sue would travel together helping others with the faculty, a series NBC declined to order (Wikipedia: *Carrie* (franchise)). The ending is clemency in the strict sense, a pardon that suspends the verdict. Yet it is clemency through a legal fiction, Carrie's staged death, and therefore a witness-protection ending: survival purchased by the erasure of identity. The commercial logic of seriality, contemporary with *X-Men* (2000) and *Smallville* (2001), which recast the gifted adolescent as a franchisable hero-inwaiting, here coincides with an ethical innovation. For the first time the corpus refuses to kill the girl.

The unmade series—a telekinetic and her advocate seeking out others like her—anticipates Flanagan's sorority by twenty-four years. The interregnum thus seeds both of the corpus's later trajectories: *The Rage*'s systemic indictment, which 2013 will individualize and 2026 will re-systematize, and the telefilm's survival-andkinship, which 2026 will realize.

PART FOUR

IV

The Superheroic Settlement

Kimberly Peirce, Lawrence D. Cohen, and Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa, 2013

CHAPTER 5 · ORIGIN STORY

CHAPTER FIVE

Origin Story

Peirce, Cohen, Aguirre-Sacasa, and the Superheroic Settlement (2013)

5.1 *After Brandon*

KIMBERLY Peirce's *Boys Don't Cry* (1999) dramatized the case of Brandon Teena, a trans man. In December 1993, in Richardson County, Nebraska, two acquaintances, John Lotter and Tom Nissen, forcibly stripped him in front of others to expose his anatomy and later that night raped him. He reported the rape; the county sheriff, Charles Laux, questioned him about it in degrading terms and made no arrest. On 31 December Lotter and Nissen murdered him in Humboldt, together with Lisa Lambert and Phillip DeVine. The sequence—forced exposure before a group, a community's violent reading of the exposed body, an authority's refusal to protect, and lethal violence—is the structure of Carrie's shower, prom, and principal's office, and Peirce brings it to *Carrie*. Jack Halberstam's *In a Queer Time and Place* (2005) identified in the earlier film a "transgender look," a gaze that briefly aligns the spectator with Brandon's self-perception before the community's reading violently overrides it. Susan Stryker's "My Words to Victor Frankenstein above the Village of Chamounix: Performing Transgender Rage" (1994), which claims the monster's rage as a transformative resource rather than a symptom, is the theoretical companion of Peirce's work as a whole. The claim is structural: it concerns how communities read bodies, not the identity of a fictional character.

5.2 *The birth prologue: natality and its near-cancellation*

The film opens not with Carrie's blood but with Margaret's. Margaret gives birth alone—having, as in the novel, mistaken her pregnancy for a cancer—and prepares to kill the newborn with a pair of scissors, then stops (Wikipedia: *Carrie* (2013 film)). Peirce re-sequences the corpus's primal scene along the maternal line: before the daughter's menarche, the mother's labor; before the shower, the bed. Hannah Arendt located the ontological root of action in natality, the fact that every birth brings a new beginning into the world, and called it the miracle that saves the world

from ruin. Margaret's scissors are the attempt to cancel natality on theological grounds.

Julianne Moore's Margaret injures herself, scratching and striking her own body, in acts the film frames as religious mortification, and her confession makes explicit that Ralph White raped her and that Carrie was conceived in that rape. She is the first Margaret whose suffering the camera honors, rendered less as tyrant than as casualty of the regime she administers. Rich's distinction between experience and institution is here dramatized within a single body.

5.3 *Hit-Girl in the shower*

Chloë Grace Moretz came to the role as Hit-Girl, the preteen vigilante of *Kick-Ass* (2010), reprised in *Kick-Ass 2* two months before *Carrie* opened. The casting imported a superheroic persona, and the direction encourages it. This Carrie researches telekinesis, practices it, levitates books and her own bed, and confronts her mother with deliberate, controlled force. The faculty is no longer an affliction that seizes her but a discipline she acquires.

5.4 *The viral gaze*

Chris Hargensen records the shower humiliation on her phone and uploads it; at the prom the video is projected on a screen behind the crowned couple at the moment the blood falls. The archive has become the weapon. The dossier that in 1974 recorded the girl after the catastrophe now precedes and produces the catastrophe, and humiliation is no longer an event but a file—reproducible, searchable, and permanent. The film's school treats the recording as a matter of discipline. In law it is more: filming a minor unclothed in a locker-room shower and publishing the footage is conduct reached by criminal statutes on voyeurism and on images of children.

The film was released into a year that had taught its audience this in three widely reported cases. In August 2012 two Steubenville High School football players in Ohio, aged sixteen and seventeen, raped an intoxicated sixteen-year-old girl during a night of parties; photographs and video of the assault circulated on social media, and in March 2013 a juvenile court convicted both. A special grand jury convened by Ohio's attorney general then indicted the district superintendent, a principal, two coaches, and the schools' technology director on charges arising from the case, including obstruction of justice, tampering with evidence, and failure to report child abuse (CNN). In Nova Scotia, Rehtaeh Parsons, fifteen, said that four boys had sexually assaulted her at a house party in November 2011. A photograph of the assault circulated through her school, police and prosecutors laid no charges, and after months of harassment she died by suicide in April 2013, at seventeen. Only

after her death did two young men, youths at the time, plead guilty to making and distributing the photograph as child pornography, and an independent review found that prosecutors had misread the law on that point (CBC). In British Columbia, Amanda Todd, fifteen, posted a video in September 2012 describing years of online sexual extortion by a stranger and the harassment that followed when he circulated an image of her; she died by suicide that October. A Dutch man, Aydin Coban, was convicted in 2022 of extortion, criminal harassment, child luring, and possession of child pornography in her case and sentenced to thirteen years (CBC).

The three cases share the film's structure: a girl's body recorded without consent, the record circulated as entertainment, and institutions slow to treat the recording itself as a crime. The institutional dimension persists from 1999. When Chris is barred from the prom, her father, a lawyer, threatens the school. Law remains an instrument of privilege, invoked for the girl who made the recording rather than the girl recorded.

5.5 *Mastery and the postfeminist sensibility*

Carrie's methodical self-education figures empowerment as skill acquisition. Rosalind Gill's account of the postfeminist sensibility (2007)—individualism, choice, self-surveillance, the makeover paradigm—describes the frame; Angela McRobbie's *The Aftermath of Feminism* (2009) describes its double entanglement, in which feminism is taken into account in order to be set aside; Sarah Banet-Weiser's *Empowered* (2018) describes the economy of visibility in which popular feminism and popular misogyny feed each other. Peirce's Carrie is the corpus's most selfactualizing, and her power is figured as personal capacity. Here lies the settlement the chapter title names. Female rage becomes legible as heroism by becoming a skill, and structural injustice becomes a set of individual villains whom a skilled individual can punish.

5.6 *The discriminating fury*

Where the 1976 Carrie's violence engulfs Miss Collins, Peirce's Carrie spares the gym teacher, Miss Desjardin, and selects her targets. Michael Walzer's *Just and Unjust Wars* (1977) codified the two principles of *jus in bello*: discrimination between combatants and noncombatants, and proportionality. The 2013 massacre approximates the first and violates the second. The philosophy of anger sharpens the analysis. Audre Lorde distinguished anger—a grief of distortions between peers, aimed at change—from hatred, aimed at death and destruction. Amia Srinivasan has argued that anger can be apt, fitting its object, even when counterproductive, and named "affective injustice" the burden placed on the wronged of choosing between apt anger and prudence. Martha Nussbaum has argued that anger's characteristic

wish for payback is normatively confused and has recommended a "Transition" toward forward-looking concern.

The 1976 Carrie enacts Lorde's hatred. The 2013 Carrie enacts Srinivasan's apt anger made lethal: her fury fits its object and is precisely what she cannot afford. Neither enacts Nussbaum's Transition—until the final scene.

5.7 *"It's a girl": the palm, the court, and the arm in the birth canal*

At home Margaret stabs her daughter in the back, closing the bracket the prologue opened: the mother who nearly killed Carrie at birth tries again. Carrie kills her, pinning her with knives and other sharp implements, and the house begins to fall. Sue arrives at the collapsing house. Carrie, about to kill her, senses that Sue is pregnant, tells her the child is a girl, and throws her to safety as stones bury the house. Sue then testifies in court about the prom, lays white roses on Carrie's defaced grave, and walks away as the headstone cracks. The palm on the belly is the corpus's second haptic event, after Fuller's breath: a touch that perceives a future life and chooses it. It is also Nussbaum's Transition in its only possible form for this Carrie, an act of forward-looking care performed in the last seconds of a life. Arendt's natality returns: the film that opened with the near-cancellation of a girl's birth closes with the protection of one. The courtroom, compressed into a single beat of plot, restores the juridical frame.

The alternate ending, which Peirce has said she preferred and which the studio judged too polarizing, carries the logic to its limit. Sue is in labor, and from the birth canal a bloodied hand—Carrie's—emerges to seize her arm before she wakes (Wikipedia; Bitch Flicks). This is the 1976 arm moved from the grave to the womb. It literalizes the recessive transmission theorized in Chapter 8: Carrie reborn through her advocate's body. The suppression of the image is itself evidence. The corpus's most radical figure of matrilineal return was judged unshowable in theaters and confined to home video.

5.8 *Aguirre-Sacasa and the witch reclaimed*

Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa's later television work reprocessed the corpus. A 2018 episode of *Riverdale* staged *Carrie: The Musical* within its fiction, and *Chilling Adventures of Sabrina* (2018–20) rewrote the teen witch as a feminist insurgent against a patriarchal Satanic church. The lineage is the reclamation of the witch: the 1968 activist group W.I.T.C.H.; Barbara Ehrenreich and Deirdre English's *Witches, Midwives, and Nurses* (1973); and Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004), which reads the early modern witch-hunts as the disciplining of women's bodies and reproductive labor at the dawn of capitalism. Margaret White's Exodus 22:18 is answered, across five centuries, by a culture that has learned to say *witch* with pride.

With Cohen's shared credit, the 2013 film is a palimpsest: the 1976 architecture overwritten by a postfeminist hand.

PART FIVE

V

The Genealogical Rehearing

Mike Flanagan, 2026

CHAPTER 6 · THE GENEALOGICAL REHEARING

CHAPTER SIX

The Genealogical Rehearing

Mike Flanagan's Carrie *(2026)*

6.1 *The eve of a text*

THIS CHAPTER IS written on the eve of its object. Flanagan's eight-episode series is released in full on 7 October 2026; Flanagan developed it, served as showrunner, wrote it with a writers' room (episodes are credited to Elizabeth Padden, Justina Ireland, Dani Parker, Elan Gale and Alexandra Magistro, and Rebecca Leigh Klingel, among others), and directed four episodes, with King as executive producer (Wikipedia: *Carrie* (miniseries)). King's first response to the prospect of another version was reportedly that the poor girl should be allowed to rest, a view he has since revised (RogerEbert.com). The analysis below rests on the series' announced architecture, Flanagan's statements, and reviews from critics who screened all eight episodes. Its conclusions are hypotheses.

Flanagan has said he did not regard the project as a straight adaptation. De Palma had adapted the novel faithfully and beautifully, the story had been remade and imitated many times, and the only purpose in returning was to build something new from its ingredients. He contrasts De Palma's Carrie, a "clenched fist" trembling in the world, with his own, who is "wide open," eager, and earnest, and he recasts Margaret as a mother who loves her daughter fiercely and protects her by enclosing her in a private utopia rather than by punishment (Wikipedia). The two revisions belong together. A Carrie without defenses and a Margaret without overt cruelty relocate the tragedy from repression to exposure.

6.2 *The 911 call and the true-crime tribunal*

The series opens with emergency calls made as the school burns on prom night, then pivots to a documentary in which survivors reconstruct the event. Sue Snell (Siena Agudong) tells the filmmaker that roughly two hundred died and a town was destroyed, and insists that everyone involved was a child doing their best (RogerEbert.com; Black Girl Nerds). The dossier returns in its contemporary form. The true-crime documentary—the dominant popular jurisprudence since *Serial*

(2014) and *Making a Murderer* (2015)—is the tribunal of the streaming era, and the 911 call is its first exhibit: the voice of terror recorded as evidence.

Sue's plea is the decisive innovation. In earlier texts the advocate pleads for Carrie; here she pleads for the whole cohort. The argument from youth echoes the United States Supreme Court's recognition, in *Roper v. Simmons* (2005), *Graham v. Florida* (2010), and *Miller v. Alabama* (2012), that adolescents bear diminished culpability. Paracletic advocacy, in other words, has become universal. Chapter 8 weighs its promise and its risk.

6.3 *The state discovers a girl*

Flanagan moves Ralph White's fatal construction accident from before Carrie's birth, where King placed it, to the threshold of her adolescence, and makes it the event that renders the family visible. Ralph is a conspiracy-minded prepper; his death leads authorities to a wife and daughter almost no one knew existed. To keep custody, Margaret must take a supermarket job and Carrie must enroll at the public high school, where she is ridiculed for having no phone and then filmed and posted online during the locker-room episode (RogerEbert.com; The Playlist).

Jacques Donzelot's *The Policing of Families* (1977) described the "tutelary complex" through which the modern state enters the household by way of schooling and social work; Flanagan dramatizes its arrival. His Carrie also belongs to an older humanist experiment. Rousseau's *Émile* (1762) imagined a child raised apart from society to preserve natural goodness, and Kaspar Hauser, who appeared in Nuremberg in 1828 after a childhood in isolation, became the nineteenth century's test case of human nature. Flanagan's Carrie is Kaspar Hauser delivered into the attention economy, and Margaret's private utopia is a perverse Rousseauian tutorship. Pre-release listings gave the episodes curricular titles such as "First Period" and "AP Physics" (Wikipedia). If they stand, the school timetable—Foucault's paradigm of disciplinary time—becomes the series' architecture, and its first pun fuses menarche with the bell schedule.

6.4 *Margaret the influencer; the account named for blood*

Critics report that Margaret learns to manipulate the community and becomes something like an influencer (RogerEbert.com). King's sect of one becomes an audience of many; the pulpit becomes the platform; *ressentiment* is monetized. Flanagan wrote the role for Samantha Sloyan, whose Bev Keane in *Midnight Mass* (2021) was a parish zealot whose certainty helped bring an island to ruin (Wikipedia). The continuity of performer makes the argument explicit: religious affect, in the platform era, organizes publics rather than closets.

The chorus that chanted in the shower has become an anonymous Instagram account, "CarrieRed_," which spreads rumors about students and teachers alike. The handle fuses the girl's name with her blood and turns the stigma into a brand. Because the account targets everyone, it universalizes the position of the scapegoat: under platform conditions, Girard's mimetic contagion has no stable victim, and anyone may be the next Carrie.

6.5 *The sorority: Joan of Arc and the genealogy of the gifted*

Flanagan has said he built outward from the novel's neglected documents—the emergency calls, police reports, testimony, and scientific inquiry that De Palma omitted—which imply that Carrie belongs to a lineage of gifted women. From the second episode, each installment follows a different woman elsewhere in the world coming to terms with the faculty, while Carrie finds her place among them (Wikipedia). One reviewer describes a larger meditation on women whose extraordinary gifts drew fear and betrayal, Joan of Arc among them (RogerEbert.com); another finds the connected-universe material distracting (The Playlist).

Joan is the historical archetype the corpus has been circling. A girl who heard voices, she was tried by an ecclesiastical tribunal, condemned as a relapsed heretic, and burned at Rouen in 1431. In 1456 a nullification trial annulled the verdict; in 1920 she was canonized. Her case is the original paracletic retrial: condemnation, rehearing, reversal, sanctification. Flanagan's sorority converts the novel's closing letter into a world-historical genealogy and Carrie's singularity into membership. Robin Morgan's *Sisterhood Is Powerful* (1970) supplied the second wave's slogan; bell hooks's *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (1984) warned that solidarity cannot be presumed from shared victimization and must be built across difference. Whether the series builds its sorority or presumes it is the question its full text must answer. The resistance of some critics to its anthology structure may register the generic cost of its central move: the conversion of tragedy into genealogy.

6.6 *A humanism of grief*

Across *The Haunting of Hill House* (2018), *Midnight Mass*, and *The Fall of the House of Usher* (2023), and across his King films *Gerald's Game* (2017), *Doctor Sleep* (2019), and *The Life of Chuck* (2024), Flanagan has used horror as a vehicle for grief, addiction, confession, and forgiveness. His signature form is the extended monologue, descended from the recovery-meeting testimony that *Midnight Mass* stages directly. His King adaptations rehearse the corpus's haptic and genealogical themes. Jessie in *Gerald's Game* frees herself from handcuffs by tearing the skin from her own hand. Abra Stone in *Doctor Sleep* is a powerful psychic girl who is mentored

rather than persecuted, and her enemies literally feed on gifted children. *Usher* sinks a house again; *Hill House* inherits Jackson's stones. Flanagan's ethics is testimonial and reparative, in Sedgwick's sense, and his cosmology is Whitmanian: *Chuck* turns on the claim that a single life contains multitudes.

6.7 *Hypotheses for the full text*

Four hypotheses follow, to be tested against the complete series. First, the verdict will be genealogical: guilt distributed across a history (from Rouen to Chamberlain) and across a networked community, with Carrie's culpability neither denied nor isolated. Second, the documentary's plea of universal youth extends clemency to all parties, and its ethical success will depend on whether clemency preserves accountability or dissolves it. Third, the sorority tests whether the corpus can move its heroine from violence to power in Arendt's sense, from sovereign isolation to action in concert. Fourth, reviewers report that the series ends on open questions (TheWrap). If so, the corpus's most recent word returns the case to the condition of its first: a dossier that cannot close.

PART SIX

VI

Theory

The Sovereign Abject and Paracletic Adaptation

CHAPTER 7 · THE SOVEREIGN ABJECT

CHAPTER 8 · PARACLETIC ADAPTATION AND THE RECESSIVE MYTH

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Sovereign Abject

Telekinesis, Exception, and the Liberal Subject

7.1 *Two endowments*

THE HUMANIST SUBJECT of modernity receives two endowments. The first is action at a distance. Francis Bacon identified knowledge with power; Descartes proposed in the sixth part of the *Discourse on Method* (1637) that knowledge would make humans masters and possessors of nature; Pico's chameleon fashions itself and its world. Modern physics placed action at a distance at its own foundation and found it scandalous: in a 1693 letter to Richard Bentley, Newton called the idea that one body might act upon another across a vacuum without mediation an absurdity no competent thinker could accept. Telekinesis is Newton's scandal returned in the body of a girl.

The second endowment is inviolability. Locke held in the *Second Treatise* (§27) that every man has a property in his own person. Kant grounded dignity in the prohibition on treating persons merely as means. Blackstone explained that the common law forbids even the lightest unconsented touch because every man's person is sacred. Combined, the endowments define the sovereign individual: one who acts upon the world without being acted upon, who touches without being touched.

7.2 *The exclusion clause*

Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) demonstrated that the social contract presupposes a prior, concealed contract securing men's access to women's bodies, and that the "individual" of contract theory is constitutively male. The common law made the exclusion explicit. Blackstone's doctrine of coverture merged a wife's legal person into her husband's, and Sir Matthew Hale's eighteenth-century dictum that a husband could not be guilty of raping his wife survived in American law until the last states abolished the marital exemption in 1993. When King published the novel, Margaret White's account of her rape by her husband described an act that most American jurisdictions did not recognize as a crime. Carrie is the child of the sexual contract's exception, conceived in a body the law did not deem inviolable.

The prom is the social contract's pageant: a ritual of pairing, courtship, and coronation in which the community displays its order to itself. *The Rage* makes the sexual contract literal as contract, a ledger of points and wagers. Carrie's admission to the pageant by coronation is the sexual contract's trap: she is invited into the order in order to be shown that she was never part of it.

7.3 *Homo sacer and sovereign: the topology of the prom*

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovers from archaic Roman law a figure who may be killed with impunity but not sacrificed, and argues that sovereign and *homo sacer* are symmetrical: the sovereign is the one for whom all are potentially *homines sacri*, and *homo sacer* is the one in relation to whom all act as sovereigns. Carl Schmitt had defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. In the shower and at the prom Carrie occupies the position of *homo sacer*. Anyone may degrade her at negligible cost, and her degradation is not sacrifice—it lacks the dignity of the sacred even as the coronation mimics sacralization.

At the moment the blood falls, the topology inverts. Carrie decides the exception: the doors seal, the normal order is suspended, and everyone in the gym becomes bare life before her. The **Sovereign Abject** is the figure in whom Agamben's two symmetrical poles become first successive and then simultaneous. In the instant of her sovereignty she remains abject—drenched, with laughing faces in her eyes—and her sovereignty is the abjection turned outward. Hobbes named his commonwealth after the sea monster of Job 41 and called it a mortal god. Carrie is a Leviathan of one, a mortal god without a commonwealth, and inside the sealed gym Hobbes's state of nature returns inverted: not the war of all against all, but of one against all.

7.4 *Strength without power*

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguishes power, which corresponds to the human ability to act in concert and belongs to a group, from violence, which is instrumental and multiplies individual strength. They are opposites: violence appears where power is in jeopardy, can destroy power, and can never create it. Carrie is the purest instance in modern fiction of maximal strength and null power. Telekinesis is strength without plurality. In *The Human Condition* (1958) Arendt describes the space of appearance, where persons disclose who they are through speech and action before others. The prom is Carrie's first appearance in public; the community answers by converting her appearance into spectacle, and her violence then destroys the space of appearance itself. The gym burns because no one would let her appear in it. Only Flanagan's sorority, at the end of the corpus, attempts to give her a plurality.

7.5 *Recognition denied*

Rousseau's *Discourse on the Origin of Inequality* (1755) locates the first step toward inequality in a scene of communal song and dance, when people gathered before their huts began to look at one another and wish to be looked at, and public esteem acquired a price. The prom is Rousseau's dance before the huts: the primal scene of *amour-propre*, the passion for comparative esteem. Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) made self-consciousness depend on recognition by another selfconsciousness. Axel Honneth's *The Struggle for Recognition* (1992) specified three spheres—love, rights, and social esteem—each with a corresponding form of disrespect: abuse, the denial of rights, and denigration. Carrie suffers all three. Margaret's abuse violates the first; the school's failure to protect her and the law's solicitude for the Hargensens violate the second; her peers' contempt violates the third. Honneth argued that experiences of disrespect drive social struggle. Carrie conducts a struggle for recognition by the only means left to her.

7.6 Ressentiment, *wounded attachment, and transgender rage*

In the *Genealogy of Morals* (I.10) Nietzsche located the slave revolt in morality at the moment *ressentiment* becomes creative: the revenge of those denied deeds becomes imaginary and generates values. Margaret is the priestess of *ressentiment*; Carrie is the slave revolt carried out in deeds. Wendy Brown's "Wounded Attachments," in *States of Injury* (1995), warned that a politics grounded in injury may become invested in its own subjection, since its claim depends on the wound. Carrie's power awakens in injury and discharges as injury, and even the corpus's "empowered" version of 2013 remains bound to the wound. Its power is the wound weaponized.

Stryker's essay of 1994 is the counterpoint. Embracing the monster's rage as the source of speech and self-making, it reads rage as transformation rather than repetition. The corpus oscillates between Brown's diagnosis and Stryker's affirmation. The haptic humanism proposed in the Conclusion is designed to leave the oscillation rather than to choose a side.

7.7 *The Frankenstein inheritance*

Mary Shelley's creature educates himself on *Paradise Lost*, Plutarch, and *Werther*, seeks the recognition of the cottagers he has secretly served, is driven off, and explains: "I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend." The sentence is Rousseau's anthropology in a single clause and could serve as an epigraph to every text in the corpus. Flanagan inscribes the intertext directly when a guidance counselor quotes *Frankenstein* to a Carrie who protests that she does not do scary (RogerEbert.com). Ellen Moers's *Literary Women* (1976), which coined the term

"Female Gothic," read *Frankenstein* as a birth myth written by a daughter whose mother, Mary Wollstonecraft, author of *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792), died days after her birth. Peirce's prologue makes *Carrie* a birth myth in the same sense.

7.8 *The telekinetic paradox*

The chapter's conclusion can be stated as a paradox. The two endowments of the humanist subject, conferred upon the figure excluded from them, do not produce a better humanist subject; they produce a monster, and in doing so they reveal that the endowments were monstrous all along. A being who acts on the world without being touched by it, who decides alone who may live, and who answers no community is not a deviation from the sovereign individual. It is the sovereign individual's truth, displayed in a body never meant to hold it. *Carrie* is a critique of sovereignty conducted from inside sovereignty's fantasy, and it asks, without yet being able to say so, for another definition of the human.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Paracletic Adaptation and the Recessive Myth

8.1 *Accuser and advocate*

In *Things Hidden since the Foundation of the World* (1978) and *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning* (1999), René Girard returned to the juridical vocabulary of scripture. The Hebrew *ha-satan* is the accuser, the prosecutor of the heavenly court (Job 1–2; Zechariah 3:1), cast down in Revelation 12:10 as "the accuser of our brethren." The Greek *paraklētos* is the one called to the side of the accused: the advocate (1 John 2:1) and the Comforter promised in John 14:16. For Girard, myth narrates the founding murder from the persecutors' side and conceals the victim's innocence; the Gospels narrate it from the victim's side and reveal it; the Paraclete is the spirit that defends victims against the accusing crowd.

From this I derive **paracletic adaptation**: a mode in which a later text functions as advocate for an earlier text's victim, reopening the case in order to shift the verdict. It differs from Hutcheon's palimpsestic pleasure and from revisionism in general by three features. It is juridical in structure, since a case is reopened; it is carried by a witness figure within the text; and it moves toward the progressive unmasking of the community's accusation. Margaret White, who accuses her daughter of witchcraft, occupies the satanic position in Girard's exact sense, an irony the corpus never states and always enacts.

8.2 *Sue Snell as Paraclete*

The witness figure is Sue Snell, whose career across six texts is the corpus's conscience. In the novel she is a participant who repents, surrenders her prom, testifies before a skeptical commission, writes a memoir in self-defense, and shares Carrie's death from within. In 1976 she is the penitent expelled from the prom by a teacher who misreads her, and the survivor whose nightmare ends the film. In 1999 she is the counselor who files charges, discloses kinship, and dies at the threshold. In 2002 she is the witness under interrogation, the one who breathes life back into Carrie, and the accomplice in her escape. In 2013 she is the pregnant girl spared by

Carrie's touch, the witness in court, and the mourner at the grave. In 2026 she is the documentary witness who pleads the youth of all.

The arc runs from accomplice to advocate to rescuer to mother to universal pleader. King has written that he never trusted Sue's motives, and the suspicion is not dispelled; advocacy is always also self-justification. The corpus's history is in part the history of a culture learning to hear Sue, and in part the history of Sue learning to deserve a hearing. The two processes cannot be separated, which is why the advocate never fully escapes the accused's shadow.

8.3 *The migrating tribunal*

The forum of judgment changes with every text: a state commission (1974); no tribunal but a dream, the unconscious convened as court (1976); a statutory-rape complaint pursued with a sheriff (1999); a police interrogation (2002); a courtroom (2013); a true-crime documentary (2026). Jurisdiction migrates from the state to the media, from adjudication to narration, from verdict to audience. Joan of Arc's case, which Flanagan invokes, sets the pattern's historical archetype. She was condemned by an ecclesiastical court in 1431, rehabilitated by a nullification trial in 1456, and canonized in 1920. The *Carrie* corpus repeats her history at the speed of popular culture.

8.4 *The verdicts*

The verdicts can now be stated. The novel's is undecidable: the dossier cannot close. De Palma's is monstrosity mitigated by pathos. Shea and Moreu's is systemic indictment. Carson and Fuller's is clemency. Peirce, Cohen, and Aguirre-Sacasa's is vindication. Flanagan's, provisionally, is a genealogical rehearing. The burden shifts from the girl's body to the community's structures and then from the community to history.

The shift is not simple progress, because each verdict exacts a price. Indictment loses Carrie herself, replaced by a half-sister. Clemency erases her identity behind a faked death. Vindication individualizes injustice into punishable villains. Genealogy risks diffusing responsibility into history. Paracletic adaptation is a dialectic of advocacy in which every gain in the defense creates a new vulnerability for the defended.

8.5 *Paranoid and reparative endings*

Sedgwick's "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading," collected in *Touching Feeling* (2003), contrasts a paranoid mode—anticipatory, mimetic, devoted to exposure, determined that no bad surprise should come unforeseen—with a

reparative mode that assembles and confers plenitude on an object so that it can offer sustenance in return. The corpus's endings stage the contest. De Palma's arm is paranoia as form, and *The Rage* inherits it as Jesse's closing hallucination. Fuller's drive to Florida is reparative. Peirce's theatrical ending, the cracking headstone, is paranoid; her preferred ending is both at once, a jump-scare that is also a birth. Flanagan's frame, which critics call compassionate, is reparative, and its reported open ending defers the choice. The history of the corpus's endings is the history of this struggle.

8.6 *The recessive myth*

Adaptation theory has long borrowed from biology. Hutcheon describes adaptations as stories that evolve and survive; Dawkins coined the meme in *The Selfish Gene* in 1976, the year of De Palma's film. The corpus does not need these external models, because it supplies its own. The novel's scientific witnesses treat the faculty as heritable, and its closing letter reports its reappearance in an infant. The theory is **recessive transmission**: a trait carried silently through a generation and expressed when conditions select for it, each expression shaped by its environment like a phenotype.

The theory makes a prediction that the corpus fulfills. Each expression multiplies Carrie's kin. The singular monster of 1974 and 1976 becomes a half-sister in 1999, a network of telekinetics in the unmade series of 2002, an unborn daughter in 2013, and a world-historical sorority in 2026. The adaptations are the epilogue's Annie grown up. The recessive myth also expresses itself in neighboring texts. The 2026 tiein edition's introduction by Margaret Atwood places the novel beside *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985), whose Gilead is, among other things, Margaret White's theology enacted as a state.

8.7 *Expressions under stress*

EXPRESSION	HISTORICAL STRESSORS	PHENOTYPE OF THE FACULTY	KINSHIP GRANTED THE GIRL
1974/1976	Second-wave feminism; *Roe* and Title IX; the evangelical resurgence; the Bicentennial	Menstrual, involuntary, apocalyptic	None; the mother's closet
1999	The Spur Posse scandal; "girl power"; the weeks before Columbine	Sexual; inscribed on the skin	A half-sister, recognized too late
2002	The first post-Columbine year; the serial superhero	Survivable, recoverable	An advocate who breathes; an unmade series of others
2013	Recorded humiliation online; postfeminist empowerment; superhero hegemony	Mastered, discriminating	An unborn daughter, foreseen
2026	Platform religiosity; true crime; the post-*Dobbs* politics of reproduction and of menstrual-data privacy; legislation on girls' locker rooms and sports; persistent school shootings	Genealogical, global	A sorority across centuries

Read down the final column, the table records a single movement: from no kin to a world of kin. Read across any row, it shows that each generation has expressed the trait in the form its own conflicts required. The two readings together constitute the recessive myth.

CONCLUSION

The Willful Arm

Toward a Haptic Humanism

I. *The willful child*

AMONG THE GRIMMS' tales is a story only a few sentences long, "The Willful Child" (KHM 117). A child will not do as her mother wishes; she sickens and dies; she is buried. But her arm keeps rising from the grave. It is pushed back and covered with fresh earth, and it rises again, until the mother goes to the grave and strikes the arm with a rod. Then it withdraws, and the child at last has rest beneath the ground. Sara Ahmed opens *Willful Subjects* (2014) with this tale. Willfulness, she argues, is the charge leveled at those who will not comply; the arm is the will's persistence, the limb that keeps protesting after the subject has been silenced; the rod is the disciplinary violence that calls itself peace. Ahmed asks us to hear the arm, and to recognize in arms—the limbs of laboring and protesting bodies—the possibility of an army of the willful.

De Palma's arm rising from Carrie's grave is the Grimms' arm, and Sue wakes into her mother's restraining embrace, the rod in its tender form. The willful arm is the corpus's master image and is older than any film: the image of the girl who will not stay buried. Every adaptation is the arm rising again. Every attempt to lay the story to rest plays the mother with the rod—including, as it happens, King's reported first response to Flanagan's project, that the poor girl should be allowed to rest. The tale and the author want the same thing. The corpus refuses it.

II. *An anatomy of hands*

An inventory of hands across the corpus shows a direction. The novel ends without physical touch: two minds meet in Carrie's dying, and the haptic is deferred into telepathy. De Palma's film offers the dead arm that seizes, the mother's arms that restrain, Carrie's arms around Margaret in the closet's pietà, and Margaret's hand on the knife. *The Rage* offers a distant hand that saves, as Rachel throws Jesse clear of the fire, and a skin inscribed by rage. Fuller offers Margaret's hands holding her daughter under water and Sue's hands on Carrie's chest, her breath in Carrie's lungs. Peirce offers Margaret's scissors over the newborn, Carrie's palm on Sue's

belly, and the suppressed arm from the birth canal. Flanagan, provisionally, multiplies arms into a sorority.

The sequence runs from the hand that seizes, to the hand that rescues, to the hand that perceives, to the hands that join. It is the corpus's ethical argument, conducted in gestures it rarely puts into words.

III. *John 20: prohibition, breath, wound*

A single chapter of the Fourth Gospel contains the corpus's three haptic gestures in order. At verse 17 the risen Christ says to Mary Magdalene, "Touch me not"—*Noli me tangere*. At verse 22 he breathes on the disciples and says, "Receive ye the Holy Ghost," bestowing the Paraclete as breath. At verse 27 he invites Thomas: "Reach hither thy hand, and thrust it into my side." Jean-Luc Nancy's *Noli me tangere* (2003) reads the prohibition not as refusal but as the condition of a touch that does not grasp; Caravaggio's *Incredulity of Saint Thomas* (c. 1601–02) paints the finger entering the wound.

The corpus traverses the chapter. It begins in sovereign untouchability, telekinesis as *noli me tangere* turned into power. It passes through breath, in Fuller's resuscitation. It arrives at the touched wound, in the testimonies of the courtroom and the documentary, where survivors put their hands, so to speak, into the injury of the town. Haptic humanism follows the same order: from untouchability, through breath, to the wound that is touched rather than avenged.

IV. *Haptic humanism: three axioms*

First, reversibility over sovereignty. Merleau-Ponty observed that when one hand touches the other, the touching hand can itself become touched; the reversibility is never complete, but it is constitutive. *The Visible and the Invisible* (1964) calls this crossing the chiasm. The human is the being who can be touched and can touch back. The telekinetic sovereign, touching without being touched, breaks the chiasm and leaves the human. Irigaray's figure in *This Sex Which Is Not One* (1977) of the two lips perpetually touching—a self-touch that is never one—and her critique of a culture that privileges sight over touch locate the same reversibility at the root of feminine pleasure. Derrida's *On Touching* (2000) supplies the decisive distinction. Tact, he suggests, is a touching that respects the untouchable in the other: touching, as it were, without touching. Telekinesis is the same formula inverted into violence. The corpus confuses the two; haptic humanism separates them. Telekinesis is tactlessness at a distance. Tact is distance kept within touch.

Second, exposure over inviolability. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *The Force of Nonviolence* (2020) ground ethics in a shared vulnerability, the fact that we are undone by one another, and ask whose lives are counted grievable. Nancy's

Corpus (1992) defines the body as exposure. On this view dignity does not mean being untouchable; it means having one's unavoidable exposure protected. The locker room, the clinic, and the classroom are places where bodies are necessarily exposed, and they must be governed by care rather than by surveillance or spectacle. The demand is not abstract. After *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* (2022) returned the regulation of abortion to the states, privacy advocates warned that records kept by menstrual-tracking apps could be sought in investigations, so that a girl's cycle could become an entry in a legal file. In the same years more than twenty states restricted transgender girls' participation in girls' sports—measures their supporters defend as protecting fairness and privacy for girls and their opponents criticize as exclusionary—and eligibility disputes have turned into official scrutiny of girls' bodies, transgender or not. In 2022 the Utah High School Activities Association, after the parents of two defeated competitors questioned whether the winning girl was transgender, reviewed her school records back to kindergarten without telling her or her family; she had been registered as female throughout (AP via WHSV). The corpus's primal scene, a community reading a girl's body, has become a matter of statute and dossier. Its first injustice was epistemic. Haptic humanism therefore includes a duty Margaret refused and the chorus exploited: to tell a girl what her body is.

Third, plurality over singularity. Arendt's power exists only in action in concert. Audre Lorde's "Uses of the Erotic" (1978) describes the erotic as a resource of deep feeling which, when shared, forms a bridge between those who share it and lessens the threat of their difference: power felt with others rather than exercised upon them. The girl's gift becomes power rather than violence only when it is held among others. The sorority that ends the corpus, so far, is the first attempt to imagine this condition.

v. *From* tele- *to* para-

The corpus's ethical movement can be compressed into a change of prefix. *Tele-*, the far: telekinesis, moving the world from a distance without contact, the endowment of the sovereign. *Para-*, the beside: the *paraklētos* called to stand beside the accused, whose Greek root also yields *paraklēsis*, consolation. Telekinesis is power without proximity. Paraclesis is proximity without domination. The Sovereign Abject becomes human at the moment someone comes to stand beside her: Sue in the roadhouse parking lot in 1974, at the burning threshold in 1999, over her drowned body in 2002, at the collapsing house in 2013, before the documentary camera in 2026.

The Introduction began with the two documents of 1486, the humanist's charter of self-fashioning and the inquisitor's manual of the witch. Haptic humanism is the

name for what reconciles them. It keeps Pico's insistence that the human is unfinished and capable of transformation, and it removes the sovereign isolation in which that capacity became indistinguishable from witchcraft. Its emblem is neither Pico's chameleon nor Hobbes's mortal god. It is the arm that rises from the ground and is taken rather than struck down.

VI. *Coda*

The arm has risen in every generation since 1974. The rod has been tried, in the form of the closet, the chant, the bucket, the camera, the ledger, the upload, and the anonymous account. What has not yet been tried, except in the corpus's most fragile and most suppressed images, is to take the hand.

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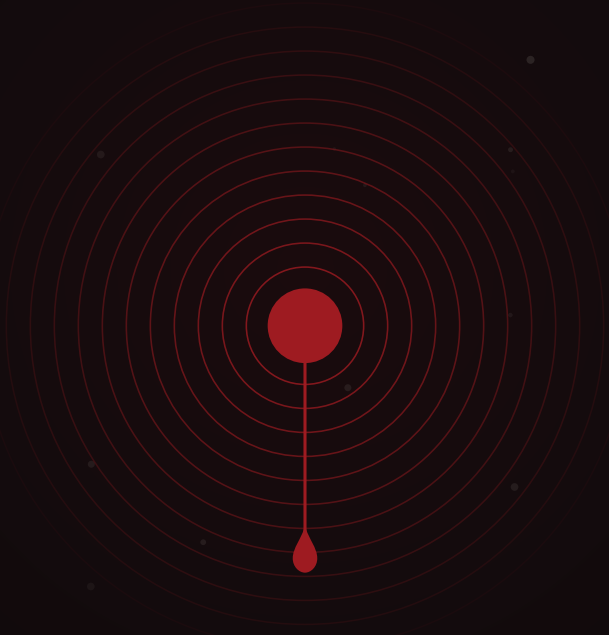
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